

Post-incident review PIR-2025-010

Notification Service: stale data shown to users

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 27 January 2025, Notification Service experienced stale data shown to users in production (US West) for about 55 minutes. The end-to-end checkout probe went red. Investigation found that one tenant's bulk import consumed most of the shared queue throughput.

Impact

Users of Notification Service saw stale data shown to users for about 55 minutes. The service owner, Messaging, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:13 First signal received.
- 09:23 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:47 Likely cause identified.
- 10:18 Mitigation applied.
- 10:31 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that one tenant's bulk import consumed most of the shared queue throughput.

The team first suspected a recent configuration change, but the change log showed nothing relevant.

The rollback script had never been exercised and failed on first use.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Load test the service at twice the expected peak before the next campaign.
- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.